

I wanted to quit after the Rio Olympics when I was 34 years old.



All smiles: Sharath Kamal after winning the gold medal at the 2022 Commonwealth Games in England. GETTY IMAGES

one to one-and-a-half hours of fitness. As it comes to June and July, 45 minutes of fitness because that is how much a match takes. Within that period, it has to be intense, and it has to be as rigorous as possible because that's how a match is.

Practice schedules will also vary in those patterns. In these three periods, what is the kind of diet that I have? What kind of recovery and sleep would I need? We discuss all of this with the playing coach and the fitness coach, and then we build up accordingly. Then, we talk to the physio, the mental coach, and the nutritionist and tell them what we are looking for.

At this point, the mental coach will have to make sure that I don't lose focus on the goal or lose confidence. When you start to build something and work on it so much, the quality drops because the quantity is increasing. When the quality drops, still, how do I keep myself up there? What are the things I need to focus

on? What is the self-talk that I need to keep doing, and what are the techniques that will help me peak going into the Paris Olympic Games?

What are your plans once you retire?

I would like to set up a high-performance centre in Chennai with the support of the state government. The paperwork is going on. The SDAT (Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu) is trying to make it a Centre of Excellence first and then have everything.

At the high-performance centre, I would be like the sporting director. I would not be coaching, but making sure the curriculum is built, training the trainers, and getting foreign coaches. Over a period of time, maybe try to build that into a national training centre so players always have a place to come back and practise.

India is a big country. One high-performance centre is not

going to be enough. We need to have it in multiple places because I can't expect somebody from the north or the east to come down to the south and get used to the weather, the customs, and the food.

Apart from that, try to also help the federation build the structure. With my administrative roles with Indian Olympic Association (IOA) and International Table Tennis Federation (ITTF), I want to build a good ecosystem for table tennis.

Some people have questioned your selection as the flagbearer of the Indian contingent for the opening ceremony in Paris...

I didn't ask for it, and I don't want to address it. There's nothing much I have to prove.

I have proved all that I have to, and the questions raised are, I feel, a lot more political than having actual substance. I don't do politics. I do sports. So, let me do my sport, and I'm happy doing that.